

Extreme rain brings fear of flood in Florence

By Kaya Equevilley

The city of Florence was placed on red code weather alert on March 14 and March 15. The alert was for heavy rains and severe flooding. During this time Mayor Sara Funaro ordered schools and public gardens or parks to close. Many other museums and stores closed due to the weather alert. Residents of the area were asked to stay indoors. There were no casualties reported and flood defense systems were in place, according to BBC News. The Tuscany president said that rescue and health service teams were on high alert.

The alert comes nearly 60 years after flooding killed 35 people in Florence. Extreme rain caused the Arno River to breach riverbanks and take over the city in 1966. Although many of today's residents were not alive for that flood, the city and its inhabitants have not forgotten it.

Trying to stay ahead of any flooding, Florence has been at work to improve flood prevention and protection throughout the city. These flood defenses were ready to be used in the recent red code weather alert.

Some American tourists say they don't understand why locals were concerned about the rains, "Nothing compared to back home," said a student from Texas who is studying in Florence for three months, Nicole Shokry.

Tourists and locals walk the streets with umbrellas to shield from rainfall near the Ponte Vecchio bridge in Florence on Friday, March 14. Earlier this day a red code weather alert went out for concern of the Arno River flooding.



The water level of the Arno River is at an extreme high with risk of flooding over the river walls on Friday in Florence.



The high water level of the Arno has flooded a typically green seating area owned by the Società Canottieri Firenze, the Italian rowing club, on Friday, March 14.



Florence local, Charlotte Farrell peers over Ponte Santa Trinita as the Arno River level continues to rise on Friday. “Since living in the city of Florence, I haven’t seen the water this high,” Farrell says.



Three women from the U.S. look over the Ponte Santa Trinita at the Arno River as they make a new plan for their day after the Gallerie degli Uffizi closed due to rain on Friday, March 14.

“I feel like her view [of Florence] is tainted,” says Renee Mikhail (with the white umbrella) who is showing her sister around (in the red jacket) Florence for the first time. Nicole Shokry, a friend of the two sisters is aware of the red alert but doesn’t understand why it appears so urgent. “This is nothing compared to back home, in Texas, there when it rains it pours,” says Shokry.



People line the streets near the Arno River with umbrellas as they continue their exploration of Florence on Friday, March 14.



Chris Maciej shields his son from the rain with a waterproof stroller covering brought from North Carolina on the Ponte Vecchio. Maciej heard about the red alert through the weather channel app and recalls the sound of a siren on Friday. “We’ve been to Europe before, and we go out rain or shine. But if we were home, we would stay inside,” says Maciej.



Inside Istituto
Suore Oblate,
guests leave their
umbrellas near the
front door, as to not
bring water
throughout the
Monastery.



Fratelli Rossetti, a shoe store near Piazza del Duomo closed early and created a defense against potential flooding on Friday, March 14 in response to the red alert. The next day the tape and cardboard were still up.



The water level on the Arno River slowly starts to return to it's normal level on Sunday. Two days after the red alert was issued.



The water level on the Arno River continues to return to a normal level after heavy rains in the week before.

